

Addictions

What's an addiction?

An addiction is a chronic dysfunction of the brain system, which rewards and motivates us if we are consuming a special substance. Our body shows symptoms if we haven't consumed this substance for a while and the brain tells us, that we are need this substance to feel well. In general, you are addicted, if you cannot live without any special thing. For example, you can be addicted to alcohol, nicotine or also to gambling. But an addiction has not be a drug like alcohol or nicotine, it can be also an activity, which must be done to feel good and satisfy your symptoms.

How does addiction work?

For example, if you smoke a cigarette, you get rewarded by the brain with a good feeling and feel motivated. The brain remembers this activity and thinks the next day, it will need this reward again. For example, smoking every day in the morning, get saved in the brain and a cycle is getting built which must be satisfied to feel good. Is this feeling not getting satisfied, the brain sends out some signals in the form of symptoms to show the person it needs a cigarette.

Signs of an addiction

People with an addiction are experiencing the following things:

- They are unable to stay away from the substance or stop the addictive behaviour
- Are displaying a lack of self-control
- Have an increased desire for the substance or behaviour
- Dismiss how their behaviour may be causing problems

Most signs of addiction relate to a person's impaired ability to maintain self-control. This includes changes that are:

- social, such as seeking out situations that encourage a substance or behaviour
- behavioural, such increased secrecy
- health related, such as insomnia or memory loss
- related to personality

Some people with addictions even prioritize to satisfy their addictions instead of going to job-meetings or meeting some friends.

The longer you are addicted, the more it can seriously interfere with you daily life. So, they can lead to permanent health complications and serious consequences like bankruptcy. If someone is addicted to something, the best way is to get help by a

doctor or getting help by an addiction-centre. But the most people do not want to get helped by some addiction-centres or a doctor, because they are ashamed of themselves or think they could handle that by themselves.

The four stages of addictions

There are four stages of addictions, it begins with the stage, where you just trying something out and can get easily away from the addiction. It ends with the stage, where you for example consume a substance everyday because you can't live without it and you indirectly accept the negative consequences of it.

The four stages are:

- experimentation: uses or engages out of curiosity
- social or regular: uses or engages in social situations or for social reasons
- problem or risk uses or engages in an extreme way with disregard for consequences
- dependency: uses or engages in a behaviour on a daily basis, or several times per day, despite possible negative consequences

What to do against an addiction.

The best way to fight against an addiction, is to get professional help. But the best plans are comprehensive, as addiction often affects many areas of life. Treatments are helping you or the person you know to stop seeking and engaging in their addiction.

Common therapy strategies are:

- medications, for mental disorders such as depression or schizophrenia
- psychotherapy, including behavioural, talk, and group therapies
- medical services, to help treat serious complications of addiction, like withdrawal during detox
- addiction case manager, to help coordinate and check ongoing treatment
- inpatient addiction treatment
- self-help and support groups

In Austria there are several addiction-centres which helps you with finding the best treatment for your addiction. They are located for example in St.Pölten or Vienna.